INTRODUCTION

By Parisian standards, it was an unusually bright morning when I stepped into the Paris–Le Bourget airport to see the Aerospace Exhibition, 1975. The rocket engines on display glistened in the light that streamed through the glass panes and bounced off the sobre white walls. I walked past the array of items on display—a liquid propulsion engine here, a prototype of a dual-frequency radar there—with my colleague P Mohana Prasad in tow.

We often travelled together on such assignments. We enjoyed each other's company, partly because of our shared passion to make India a space superpower, and partly because of our differences that helped fill the gaps between our common goal and our varying perceptions on how to achieve it.

Prasad, who went on to develop India's Vikas engine with me, would brood over scientific puzzles for days. He would run multiple tests and cross-check results before commenting on something scientific. I, on the other hand, would sometimes be impulsive, even on scientific matters. I might look at a microscopic groove in an intricate engine, and, before scientific validation, instinctively say that the depth is two microns, and not one micron as planned. We all knew very well that the unaided human eye couldn't see the difference; nevertheless I 'saw' something that impelled me to comment. Indeed, we would run it through tests to ascertain the depth of the groove—and my instant, scientifically unaided, observation would be correct, nine out of ten times.

That morning at the Paris-Le Bourget Airport presented me with one such moment of instant cognition—a 'Blink' moment, as Malcolm Gladwell called it. It was a moment that would eventually lead me to a series of incidents—apparently normal, some even unconnected—that